# Manchester United 2021: Solving the Wrong Problem

A data-led counterfactual on output vs control in squad-building decisions

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## 1. THE DIAGNOSIS

In 2021, Manchester United added Cristiano Ronaldo to increase attacking output. But the underlying data suggests the team's more urgent issue was not chance creation. It was control: midfield stability, defensive transitions, and the ability to protect the back line.

> **United did not buy the wrong player as much as they bought the wrong solution. United added output when they needed control.**

## 2. EVIDENCE SNAPSHOT

| | 2020/21 | 2021/22 |
|---|---|---|
| POINTS | 74 | 58 |
| XG DIFF / MATCH | +0.56 | +0.01 |
| XGA / MATCH | 1.10 | 1.50 |
| SHOTS AGAINST / MATCH | 11.37 | 13.47 |

The decline was not only a table-position story: United lost most of their underlying xG cushion while conceding more chance quality and shot volume.

## 3. MODEL APPROACH

- Public match-level Premier League data.
- Variables: goals, xG, xGA, shots for, shots against.
- Poisson goal simulation estimated win/draw/loss probabilities under alternative team profiles.
- Counterfactual: no Ronaldo, but a control-oriented midfielder improves defensive stability and shot suppression.

> **This is a transparent scenario model, not a causal proof.**

## 4. COUNTERFACTUAL RESULT

2021/22 Points Scenario. Control improves the expected points profile, but does not transform the team.

**The team tried to raise its ceiling, but failed to protect its floor.**

## 5. PLAYER PROFILE / RECRUITMENT IMPLICATION

A control-oriented midfielder should:

- receive under pressure
- progress play safely
- reduce central transition exposure
- protect rest defence
- improve territorial stability
- reduce the number of defensive duels the back line has to face

> **The next signing should not only win duels. It should prevent some of them from happening.**

## ANALYTICAL CAUTION

The model does not suggest one transfer fixes United. It suggests a control-oriented squad build plausibly improves the team's floor. The conclusion is directional: the uplift depends on scenario assumptions, but the diagnosis is stable across mild/base/strong cases.

## 6. DECISION TAKEAWAY

Data should not just measure performance after the fact. It should help define the problem before capital is deployed.

> **Before buying output, diagnose the constraint.**

Source: OGS counterfactual project outputs and sample_article.html; public match-level Premier League data.